Project: Worked examples
Title: Enclosure heat dissipation and fan sizing
Status: DRAFT · Author: TempestOS (2026-10-23) · Checker: — (—) · Issued: —

1. Scope and method

Total heat load inside a control enclosure, the effective surface that can dissipate it for the mounting condition, the internal temperature rise with natural convection and radiation through a stated overall heat-transfer coefficient, the forced-ventilation airflow for a target rise (density corrected for altitude), the fan duty point against a fan curve and the system resistance, optional solar gain, and the cooling-unit capacity needed when the limit cannot be met.

WHAT IT CALCULATES	RELATION
Heat dissipated inside the enclosure, plus any solar gain	$P = \Sigma P_i n_i d_i (+ \alpha I A_{sun})$
Effective cooling surface, each face weighted by how freely it sheds heat	$A_{eff} = \Sigma f_{face} \times A_{face}$
Temperature rise with natural cooling, one coefficient over the exposed faces (the IEC TR 60890 tables are not used)	$\Delta T = P/(h A_{eff})$
Air flow a fan must move to hold the target rise	$V = P/(\rho c_p \Delta T_{target})$, with $\rho = p(z)/(287.055 T)$ and c_p = 1006 J/(kg·K)
Fan duty point, where the fan curve meets the system resistance (found by bisection)	$p_{fan}(V) = p_{sys} (V/V_{ref})^2$
Cooling unit capacity, when the surfaces alone cannot reject the heat	$P_{cool} = P - h A_{eff} (T_{max} - T_{amb})$
Sealed enclosure (sealing temperature T_{seal} entered, no breather), pressure difference across the walls when the air warms or cools from the sealing temperature at constant volume, in absolute temperatures (a rise when $T_{int} > T_{seal}$, a suction when below)	$\Delta p = p_{site} \cdot \lvert T_{int}/T_{seal} - 1 \rvert$
A pressure-compensation element (breather or relief) limits it to its cracking pressure	$dp_{seal} = \min(\Delta p, dp_{relief})$
Force of that pressure on a cover of area A_{cover}	$F_{seal} = dp_{seal} \cdot A_{cover}$

Basis: A method of temperature-rise verification of low-voltage switchgear and controlgear assemblies by calculation[1]; Effective surface, heat-transfer coefficient and fan-sizing practice (cited, not copied)[2]; Verification of temperature rise[3](10.10).

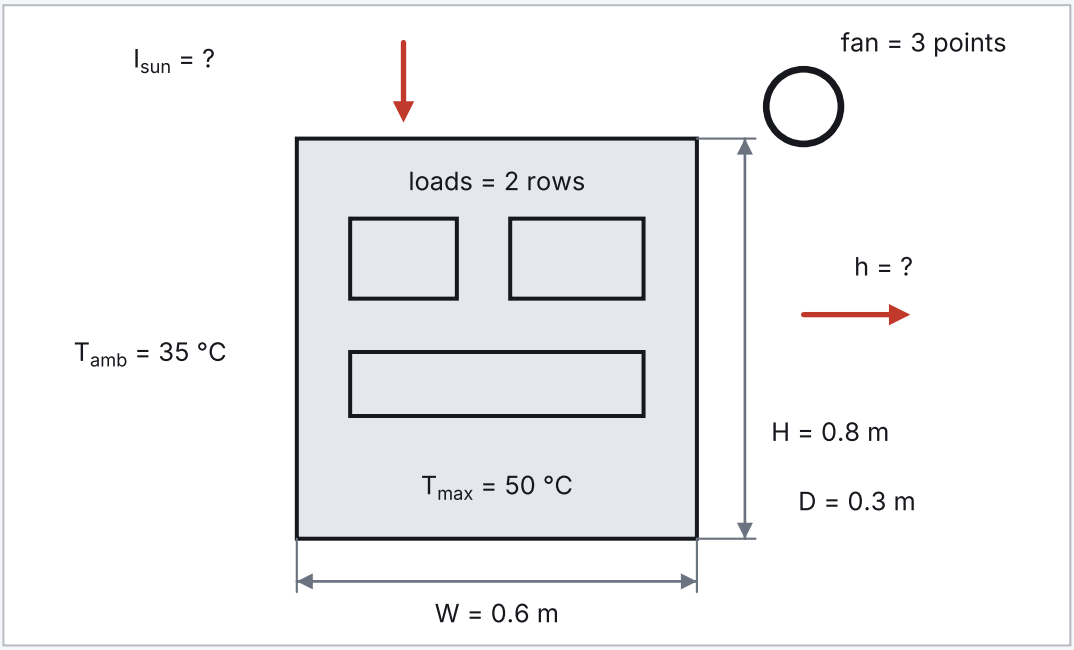


Figure 1 — An enclosure W by H by D holding the heat loads as listed, losing heat through its exposed faces to the ambient, with a fan and the sun on it. Not to scale; the labels are the inputs as entered.

2. Inputs

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
loads	Heat loads	2 row(s)		spec: Panel schedule PNL-04	any
P_{add}	Additional heat load (linked from E6's dissipated heat or another calculation)	0	W	default	0 … 100000 W
I_{sun}	Solar irradiance on the enclosure (0 = indoors)	0	W/m²	default	0 … 1200 W/m²
A_{sun}	Sunlit area	0	m²	default	0 … 100 m²
α_{sun}	Surface absorptivity	0.5		default	0.1 … 1
W	Enclosure width	0.6	m	spec: Enclosure datasheet AE-1380: 600 × 800 × 300	0.1 … 5 m
H	Enclosure height	0.8	m	spec: Enclosure datasheet AE-1380: 600 × 800 × 300	0.1 … 5 m
D	Enclosure depth	0.3	m	spec: Enclosure datasheet AE-1380: 600 × 800 × 300	0.1 … 5 m
f_{top}	Top exposure (1 free, 0 covered)	1		default	0 … 1
f_{front}	Front exposure	1		default	0 … 1
f_{rear}	Rear exposure (0 = wall-mounted)	0		default	0 … 1

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
f_{left}	Left side exposure	1		default	0 … 1
f_{right}	Right side exposure	1		default	0 … 1
f_{bottom}	Bottom exposure (0 = on the floor)	0		default	0 … 1
h	Overall heat-transfer coefficient of the enclosure surface (editable reference value)	5.5	W/(m²·K)	default	3 … 8 W/(m²·K)
T_{amb}	Ambient temperature	35	°C	spec: Site conditions SC-2: 35 °C plant room; 50 °C inside limit for the drives	-20 … 55 °C
T_{max}	Maximum internal temperature	50	°C	spec: Site conditions SC-2: 35 °C plant room; 50 °C inside limit for the drives	20 … 80 °C
altitude	Site altitude (air density)	0	m	assumption: Wall mounted on a floor plinth: rear and bottom covered; indoors.	0 … 4000 m
V_{pts}	Fan curve: airflow points	[0, 100, 200]	m³/h	spec: Fan datasheet FF-120: curve points	any
p_{pts}	Fan curve: static pressure points	[60, 30, 0]	Pa	spec: Fan datasheet FF-120: curve points	any
p_{sys}	System resistance (filters, grilles) at the reference airflow	20	Pa	spec: Filter datasheet: 20 Pa at 100 m³/h	0 … 500 Pa
V_{ref}	Reference airflow for the system resistance	100	m³/h	spec: Filter datasheet: 20 Pa at 100 m³/h	1 … 100000 m³/h

TABLE ROW	VALUES
loads[1]	name = PLC and I/O; P = 80 W; qty = 1; duty = 1
loads[2]	name = drives; P = 55 W; qty = 4; duty = 1

3. Assumptions

A1. Heat leaves the enclosure through its exposed faces at one overall coefficient h (natural convection plus radiation to surroundings at the ambient temperature); covered faces dissipate nothing. (Plain exposed-area method of manufacturer practice, not an IEC TR 60890 verification; h is a reference value the user may edit.)
A2. Forced ventilation removes the full heat load with air entering at ambient and leaving at the target rise; natural dissipation is neglected for the airflow (conservative). (Manufacturer fan-sizing practice.)
A3. A sealed enclosure (T_{seal} entered) is a closed, rigid, leak-free volume of dry air at the site pressure when closed: the pressure difference follows from the ideal-gas relation at constant volume, from the

sealing temperature to the internal temperature with natural dissipation T_{int} (the temperature without a cooling unit); a breather, a seal that leaks or a flexing wall reduces it, so it is an upper bound (a pressure-compensation element is modelled only as a cap at its cracking pressure, with no flow resistance); the site pressure is the standard atmosphere at the altitude. (Ideal gas at constant volume (derived).)
A4. The fan curve is linear between the entered points; the system resistance scales with airflow squared. (Duty-point idealisation.)
A5. altitude (Site altitude (air density)) is taken as 0 m. (Wall mounted on a floor plinth: rear and bottom covered; indoors.)
A6. The effective surface is the plain exposed-area method of manufacturer practice: each face area weighted by how freely it sheds heat, one overall coefficient h. This is not a verification of temperature rise to IEC TR 60890 or BS EN 61439-1 cl. 10.10 (neither the surface factors nor the standard's temperature-rise correlation is used). (Stated on every run so the result is not read as an assembly verification.)

4. Working

[18] $P_{loads} = \Sigma\ P_i \times n_i \times d_i$
$= 2\ item(s)$
$= 300\ W$
Internal heat load

[19] $P_{solar} = \alpha_{sun} * I_{sun} * A_{sun}$
$= 0.5 \times 0\ W/m^2 \times 0\ m^2$
$= 0\ W$
Solar gain

[20] $P_{total} = P_{loads} + P_{add} + P_{solar}$
$= 300\ W + 0\ W + 0\ W$
$= 300\ W$
Total heat to remove

[21] $A_{eff} = f_{top} * W * D + f_{bottom} * W * D + f_{front} * W * H + f_{rear} * W * H + f_{left} * H * D + f_{right} * D$ [1](verification)
$= 1 \times 0.6\ m \times 0.3\ m + 0 \times 0.6\ m \times 0.3\ m + 1 \times 0.6\ m \times 0.8\ m + 0 \times 0.6\ m \times 0.8\ m + 1 \times 0.8\ m \times 0.8\ m \times 0.3\ m$
$= 1.14\ m^2$
Effective dissipating surface

[22] $dT_{nat} = P_{total} / (h * A_{eff})$
$= 300\ W / (5.5\ W/(m^2 \cdot K) \times 1.14\ m^2)$
$= 47.847\ K$
Temperature rise with natural dissipation

[23] $T_{int} = T_{amb} + dT_{nat}$
$= 35\ degC + 47.847\ K$
$= 82.847\ degC$
Internal temperature with natural dissipation

[24] $dT_{allow} = T_{max} - T_{amb}$
$= 50\ degC - 35\ degC$
$= 15\ K$
Allowed rise

[25] $u_{nat} = dT_{nat} / dT_{allow}$
$= 47.847\ K / 15\ K$
$= 3.1898$
Natural dissipation utilisation

[26] $P_{nat,max} = h * A_{eff} * dT_{allow}$
$= 5.5\ W/(m^2 \cdot K) \times 1.14\ m^2 \times 15\ K$
$= 94.05\ W$
Heat the enclosure dissipates naturally at the limit

[27] $P_{cool} = \max(0\ W,\ P_{total} - P_{nat,max})$
$= \max(0\ W,\ 300\ W - 94.05\ W)$
$= 205.95\ W$
Cooling-unit capacity needed if ventilation is not used
[28] $p_{site} = 101325\ (1 - 2.25577e\text{-}5\ z)^{5.2559}$
$= z = 0\ m$
$= 101.32\ kPa$
Site pressure
[29] $\rho_{air} = p_{site} / (287.055\ J/(kg*K) * T_{amb})$
$= 101.32\ kPa / (287.055\ J/(kg*K) \times 35\ degC)$
$= 1.1455\ kg/m^3$
Air density at ambient and altitude
[30] $V_{req} = P_{total} / (\rho_{air} * 1006\ J/(kg*K) * dT_{allow})$
$= 300\ W / (1.1455\ kg/m^3 \times 1006\ J/(kg*K) \times 15\ K)$
$= 62.481\ m^3/h$
Airflow for forced ventilation at the allowed rise (natural dissipation neglected)
[31] $V_{req,net} = \max(0\ m\text{^}3/h,\ (P_{total} - P_{nat,max}) / (\rho_{air} * 1006\ J/(kg*K) * dT_{allow}))$
$= \max(0\ m\text{^}3/h,\ (300\ W - 94.05\ W) / (1.1455\ kg/m^3 \times 1006\ J/(kg*K) \times 15\ K))$
$= 42.893\ m^3/h$
Airflow crediting natural dissipation
[36] $V_{duty} = p_{fan}(V) = p_{sys}\ (V/V_{ref})^2$, bisection
=
$= 113.75\ m^3/h$
Fan duty airflow
[37] $p_{duty} = p_{sys}\ (V_{duty}/V_{ref})^2$
$= 20 \times (113.7/100)^2$
$= 25.876\ Pa$
Static pressure at duty
[38] $u_{fan} = V_{req} / V_{duty}$
$= 62.481\ m^3/h / 113.75\ m^3/h$
$= 0.5493$
Airflow utilisation (required / delivered)

5. Results

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
P_{total}	300 W	Total heat
P_{cool}	206.0 W	Cooling unit needed
$P_{nat,max}$	94.05 W	Natural dissipation at the limit
T_{max}	50 °C	Internal temperature limit
dT_{nat}	47.85 K	Natural temperature rise
T_{int}	82.85 °C	Internal temperature (natural)
V_{req}	62.48 m³/h	Required airflow
V_{duty}	113.7 m³/h	Fan duty airflow
P_{loads}	300 W	Internal heat load
P_{solar}	0 W	Solar gain
A_{eff}	1.140 m²	Effective surface
ρ_{air}	1.145 kg/m³	Air density

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
$V_{req,net}$	42.89 m³/h	Required airflow (net)
p_{duty}	25.88 Pa	Fan duty pressure
u_{fan}	0.55	Airflow utilisation

6. Checks (governing first)

RESULT	CHECK	DEMAND	CAPACITY	UTILISATION	REF
FAIL	Natural dissipation holds T_{max}	u_{nat} = 3.19	u_{nat} ≤ 1	3.19	
PASS	Fan delivers the required airflow	u_{fan} = 0.55	u_{fan} ≤ 1	0.55	

7. Applicability

WARNING T_{max}: natural dissipation holds 94.05 W of 300 W; ventilate or fit a 206 W cooling unit. [cooling-unit]

Defaults used (inputs left empty):
P_{add}: not entered, so the default of 0 W is used.
I_{sun}: not entered, so the default of 0 W/m² is used.
A_{sun}: not entered, so the default of 0 m² is used.
α_{sun}: not entered, so the default of 0.5 is used.
f_{top}: not entered, so the default of 1 is used.
f_{front}: not entered, so the default of 1 is used.
f_{rear}: not entered, so the default of 0 is used.
f_{left}: not entered, so the default of 1 is used.
f_{right}: not entered, so the default of 1 is used.
f_{bottom}: not entered, so the default of 0 is used.
h: not entered, so the default of 5.5 W/(m²·K) is used.

8. Verification

`Template elec.enclosure-heat@1.5.1 Content hash 6c68c61c7df7f4fe Engine calc-engine/1.0.0`
`Known-answer cases passed 4/4 Test run 2026-10-23 12:00 UTC TempestOS 0.26.0`

9. References

1. International Electrotechnical Commission. A Method of Temperature-Rise Verification of Low-Voltage Switchgear and Controlgear Assemblies by Calculation. IEC TR 60890. IEC.
2. Rittal; nVent Hoffman. Enclosure climate control guides [manufacturer technical literature].
3. British Standards Institution. Low-Voltage Switchgear and Controlgear Assemblies—Part 1: General Rules. BS EN 61439-1. BSI.